not been reached by 28 October will be discussed later. But what about launching a bolt out of the blue before the Soviets were ready in the days after 16 October? Was secret intelligence decisive in dissuading JFK from this? McGeorge Bundy was intimately involved in all ExComm meetings (whereas Richard Helms was present at none). Bundy's view was that Penkovsky had no 'discernible relation to the assessments and actions of the US government in the missile crisis'.[29] Raymond Garthoff had been the CIA analyst who previously assessed Penkovsky's intelligence; he later described the 'tremendous amount of important military information,' supplied by the colonel, but argued this was merely 'useful background information during the crisis.'[30].

The first blow of an air attack could not guarantee destruction of all the targets. Moreover, the whereabouts of other missile sites had yet to be established. At the first meeting on 16 October, General Maxwell Taylor made clear that an attack on the missiles will 'never be a hundred per cent, Mr. President,' but would require 'continuous air attack.'[31] He emphasised the point in all subsequent discussions of an air strike.

At this stage, the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs advocated a three-phase approach, beginning with an initial pause to achieve readiness, followed by air strikes against missiles, airfields and known nuclear storage sites; there would then be a decision whether to invade. For Taylor, that decision would be 'the hardest question militarily in the whole business,' which needed close consideration 'before we get our feet in that deep mud in Cuba.'[32] He nevertheless emphasised the importance of surprise and the need to, 'take them out without any warning whatsoever' (though he did not preclude some diplomatic measures outlined by Secretary Rusk to notify allies before striking).[33]

Over the next couple of days, discussion crystallised around the choice of attack or blockade. Various officials put pen to paper. The Secretary of the Treasury, Douglas Dillon (one of two Republicans in Kennedy's cabinet), argued in favour of the air attack. In a memorandum for Kennedy on 17 October (circulated to ExComm), he warned that 'sooner or later and probably sooner we will lose all Latin America to Communism.' Dillon argued: 'I, therefore, believe that the survival of our nation demands the